

## Chapter 3 — Karma Yoga

कर्मयोगः : కర్మయోగము

"The Yoga of Action" · 43 verses · You cannot escape action — but you can transform it

Arjuna's natural reaction to Ch 2 is: *"If knowledge is supreme, why must I act at all? Why not just renounce?"*

Kṛṣṇa's answer in Ch 3 is uncompromising: **"No one can remain even for a moment without action."** Even breathing, even sitting, even thinking — all are action. The choice is not between acting and not acting; it is between acting *selfishly* and acting *as offering* (yajña) — for the welfare of all beings (loka-saṅgraha).

### Essential verses of Chapter 3

**BG 3.5** You cannot escape action — even for a moment

न हि कश्चित्क्षणमपि जातु तिष्ठत्यकर्मकृत् ।

कार्यते ह्यवशः कर्म सर्वः प्रकृतिजैर्गुणैः ॥ ३.५ ॥

న హి కశ్చిత్క్షణమపి జాతు తిష్ఠత్యకర్మకృత్ ।

కార్యతే హ్యవశః కర్మ సర్వః ప్రకృతిజైర్గుణైః ॥ 3.5 ॥

na hi kaścit kṣaṇam api jātu tiṣṭhaty akarma-kṛt |

kāryate hy avaśaḥ karma sarvaḥ prakṛti-jair guṇaiḥ |

"No one can remain, even for a moment, without performing action.

All are compelled to act, helplessly, by the qualities born of nature."

### Word-by-Word — 3.5

| IAST         | वर्णमाला   | ROMAN      | PRONUNCIATION   | MEANING                                 |
|--------------|------------|------------|-----------------|-----------------------------------------|
| na hi        | न हि       | న హి       | na hi           | indeed, not                             |
| kaścit       | कश्चित्    | కశ్చిత్    | KASH-chit       | anyone                                  |
| kṣaṇam api   | क्षणम् अपि | క్షణమ్ అపి | KSHA-nam A-pi   | even for a moment                       |
| jātu         | जातु       | జాతు       | JAA-tu          | ever, at any time                       |
| tiṣṭhati     | तिष्ठति    | తిష్ఠతి    | TISH-tha-ti     | remains, stands                         |
| akarma-kṛt   | अकर्मकृत्  | అకర్మకృత్  | a-KAR-ma-krit   | one who does no action                  |
| kāryate      | कार्यते    | కార్యతే    | KAAR-ya-te      | is made to act                          |
| hi           | हि         | హి         | hi              | indeed                                  |
| avaśaḥ       | अवशः       | అవశః       | a-VA-shah       | helplessly, against one's will          |
| karma        | कर्म       | కర్మ       | KAR-ma          | action                                  |
| sarvaḥ       | सर्वः      | సర్వః      | SAR-vah         | everyone                                |
| prakṛti-jaiḥ | प्रकृतिजैः | ప్రకృతిజైః | pra-KRI-ti-jaiḥ | born of nature (prakṛti)                |
| guṇaiḥ       | गुणैः      | గుణైః      | GU-naiḥ         | by the qualities (sattva, rajas, tamas) |

